founded on the east edge of what we now think of as Middle Eastern land, had pushed its way through the Khyber Pass into India; the Ghaznavids had then lost hold of their Middle Eastern territories, becoming simply a north Indian kingdom. In 1150, the Ghaznavid kingdom was in the hands of Bahram Shah, at the end of a particularly splendiferous thirty-five-year reign. Bahram Shah was a vassal of the Turkish sultan of Khorasan, Ahmed Sanjar, at that time the senior member of the clan (the "Great Seljuk"). Bahram was a patron of poets, mathematicians, and philosophers. At his court, a visitor might find the poet Firdausi, originally from Khorasan, busy composing his epic history called the *Shahnameh* (now considered the national epic of Iran), or the astronomer Al Biruni, hard at work on one of his 146 books on science and mathematics.

But all was not well on the Ghaznavid borders. The control of the Great Seljuk over his lands was weakening; his superiority over the other Turkish sultans had long been in name rather than in fact. Another of the Great Seljuk's vassals, a clan known as the Ghurids, was agitating for freedom.

The Ghurids lay on Bahram Shah's western flank; he feared them as much as the Great Seljuk did. He had attempted to stave off an attack by marrying his daughter to one of the members of the ruling family of Ghur but when intelligence reached him that his son-in-law was planning an attack, Bahram Shah had him poisoned.

Instead of heading off hostilites, the murder ignited them. The dead man's brother, 'Ala' al-Din Husain, took revenge by leading an army into Bahram Shah's territory. The Ghaznavid army tried to face the Ghurid clan down with a vast front of elephants, but Husain and his men triumphed. The *Tabakat-i-Nasiri*, written by the Persian historian Minhaj Siraj Juzjani, tells of Husain's rallying of his warriors, tasking each with the job of bringing one elephant to the ground. "Each of those champions attacked an elephant," Juzjani writes, "and got beneath the armour of the animals, and with their poniards [daggers], ripped open the bellies of the elephants." At least one champion was crushed beneath his falling prey, but the Ghurid infantry advanced behind this offensive, protected by the *karwah*, a mobile breastwork made of bull hide and coarse cotton cloth. "When the foot-soldiers of Ghur place this screen upon their shoulders," says the *Tabakat-i-Nasiri*, "they are completely covered from head to foot by it . . . like a wall; and no missile or arms can take any effect on it, on account of the quantity of cotton with which it is stuffed."[8]

Pushing steadily forward, the Ghurid front chased the retreating Ghaznavid army all the way back to Bahram Shah's capital city. For seven days, Husain and his army sacked, burned, stole, and destroyed. As a final